

A TASTE OF LUXURY

In 1982, India's first luxury tourist train, the Palace on Wheels, rolled out of Delhi, packed with tourists eager to experience the lavish, opulent lifestyle of India's royals. It changed the way Indians looked at train travel, which was no longer a utilitarian tool, but offered opportunities of unparalleled luxury, a way to live life king-size.

"... at midnight the Prince drove to the Special Train stabled at Kirkee where the servants had arranged luxurious beds in the carriages, and in half an hour more they were rattling away from the former capital of Peshwas, on their return trip to Bombay, sleeping as securely as they were at home," recounted William Howard Russell, the honorary private secretary of the Prince of Wales, Albert Edward, who was touring India in 1875. This was his first trip to India and he was suitably impressed by the "Special Train". Almost a home away from home, the East Indian Railway (EIR) built it for the occasion, surpassing itself in 1905 during the next royal visit when it built nine saloon carriages, of which seven were longer than what ran in England at the time. Full-sized baths with showers and douches, a first, were also added.

In the pre-Independence era, luxury trains were used mostly by the affluent and royals. Elaborate, opulent coaches were the norm for the Viceroys and a source of pride for the royalty, whether it was the Gaekwad of Baroda, Maharajas of Jaipur and Jodhpur, or the Nizam of Hyderabad.

The monopoly of the royals over luxury ended towards the end of the 20th century with the introduction of the Palace on Wheels in 1982. The tourist train drew inspiration from its royal past and proved its potential as a tool of profit. Luxury rail travel was now available to those willing, and able, to pay for it.